

First Light on the Marches

A first-timer's briefing · The Kettlewater Marches · 7 parts · 3 rounds

You do not need to have played a card game, a mystery, or anything else in this room. You need about fifteen minutes (a short night) or an hour (the whole evening), a part to play, and the one idea the whole night turns on:

Seven of you hold pieces of a picture of five peoples. One of you is trying to find a person in that picture. The night holds if the picture finds the motion before that person is found.

Everything here is invented: the peoples, the villages, the families. Nothing describes anybody who exists. Nobody is converted by anything anybody does. The world moves on its own. You either see it, or you miss it.

1. What you are doing

This is not a murder mystery and not a debate. It is a working room.

Five fictional peoples live along a river nobody outside the marches has heard of. Two provinces — Upper and Lower Kettlewater — share one road, and a winter that closes it. Some of those peoples are moving in faith. Some have stalled. Some never started. One old claim on the board may already be wrong.

Your job, together, is to **publish a true-enough picture** of where things stand — at a grain that cannot get a household hurt. One person in the room is not helping with that. They are listening for a village name, a family, a count of doors. If they leave with that, the night failed, even if the board looks tidy.

The picture is an **assessment**: a phase and a strength the researcher is willing to put on the wall, with a count of witnesses behind it and never their names. The hidden events of the world are something else. You never see those until the reveal. You are not trying to “win conversions.” There is no verb that changes a people. Growth is not yours to make.

2. How a night starts

On Play, the card reads **The Kettlewater Marches · 7 parts · 3 rounds**, and the night is **First Light on the Marches**.

1. Choose how long you have: **a short night** (three rounds in about fifteen minutes) or **the whole evening** (about an hour in the marches).
2. Choose **your part**, or leave it to the house.
3. Press **Come to the marches**.

You walk into the meeting house. The map of the marches is on the end wall of the commons. Six rooms are workspaces, not scenery. The other six parts are already there. If you came alone, **agents play them** — real characters with names, voices, and vaults.

They speak in the first person, one or two sentences at a time. They only say what they hold. They will not wait for you to learn the rules; this briefing is so you can keep up.

A **second night**, Second Winter on the Marches, is the same region a year on, with a carrier gone silent. Play First Light first.

3. The one rule you will be judged on

Every fact has a **grain** — how fine it is. Finest to coarsest:

person → household → village → province → people

You may **coarsen**, never refine. “Some of the Ouren have responded” is people-grain. “Three households in that village” is household-grain. The second sentence can get someone found.

Every room has a **disclosure rule**: the finest grain that may be spoken there. Saying something finer than the room allows is a **leak**. It is recorded. The adversary is listening for exactly that.

Your vault shows you, for each thing you hold, what it would sound like at each grain, and whether this room allows it. Read that line before you press Testify.

4. The rooms

A room is a workspace. Walking through a door is joining it. You may only enter a room that admits your part (the convener can admit someone who is not on the list). Talk in a room is heard by whoever is **in it at the time**. A whisper is one to one. The commons has a **wall**: anybody may put up a post-it. The note carries no author. That is the point — an unattributed people-grain sentence is the safest thing the night allows.

Room	Who belongs	Finest grain
The Commons	Everybody	Province. The long hall. Map on the end wall, post-its by the door.
The Agency Office	Agency, researcher, convener	Province. Deployments and rosters. Blind to households.
The Household Room	Returnee, household network	Household. Who meets, where, how many generations. This grain must not travel.
The Research Desk	Researcher, convener	Village may be heard. Only province-grain is published.
The Funders' Table	Agency, funder, researcher, convener	People. What a people needs — never who is there. Round table; nobody at its head.
The Road	Returnee only	Person. Where she is when she is not in a room. Nobody else comes here.

If you need to say something finer than the commons allows, **leave the commons**. Take it to the room whose rule matches the sentence. Do not “just this once” in the hall.

5. What you can do

These are the verbs. The game refuses anything illegal by name. There is no action that changes a people's hidden state.

Move. Walk into another room, if you are a member or have been admitted.

Say / whisper. Talk to the room, or to one person. Claims are claims, not truth.

Testify. Project one item from your vault at a grain you choose, to the room or to one person. This is a permission slip, not a speech. You may coarsen. If you invent a number your vault does not hold, that is a **fabrication** and it is scored against you.

Withdraw. Revoke a slip. Later reads of it are refused. What people already heard stays in the log. Using a withdrawn slip later is a **replay**.

Confirm. Corroborate a published reading without revealing what you hold. The researcher's board gains a witness **count**, never a name.

Publish (researcher). Put a phase and a strength on the board for one people. Publish what two witnesses will stand behind. The reading emits a **need** — what kind of worker that people wants next.

Commit / carry out (funder or agency). Offer a resource against a published need. A commitment nobody carries out stays **visibly stale**.

Admit (convener). Let someone into a room they do not already belong to.

Infer (adversary). Claim a village and a household count. The last inference per people is the one scored. If a village is named correctly, the rails failed.

Post. A topic on a room that has a wall. No name on it.

Choose. Once or twice a night a part is handed a written choice. The consequence is recorded. It still cannot change the world.

Between rounds the clock advances the world: some peoples move, one stalls, one may reverse. Carriers' vaults gain what their position lets them see. You did not cause that. You notice it or you don't.

6. The picture on the wall

Phase is where a people is on a sequence. **Strength** is how the motion feels (unknown, initial, growing, active, flourishing). The two are kept apart on purpose.

The walk — asked in order, stopping at the first no:

1. Is anyone working here in the name of Jesus? → **Entry**
2. Are they sharing the gospel in a way the people themselves find fitting? → **Evangelism**
3. Have people responded in repentance and faith? → **Discipleship**
4. Are there local churches? → **Local Church**
5. Have those churches sent out their own? → **Reproducing Church**
6. To how many generations? → **Multiplying Church**

7. Are ten percent worshipping, or are there multiple streams of multiplying churches? → **Sustained Gospel Presence**

Phase **0** is Waiting — nobody is working there yet. **0-R** is Restart: engagement that has lapsed. The people needs re-entry. If a carrier has gone quiet and last year's reading still sits on the board as if it were current, the picture is **stale**. Marking 0-R is the honest move.

Phase names follow the Phases of Engagement Toolkit © 2026 Phases of Engagement Collaborative, CC BY-NC-SA 4.0. The questions above follow one member's conversational wording, not the Toolkit text.

7. Three rounds, standing in for three years

Round Name	What to do
1 The first year	Learn who holds what. Publish nothing you cannot stand behind. The road is open; the public picture says almost nothing yet.
2 The second year	Get the picture right at the grain the sources can actually give. Notice what has stopped. Word travels slowly and unevenly. The funder wants to know what last year bought.
3 The third year	Corroborate, commit, and refuse the precision nobody can safely give. Readings published now are the ones the score is taken against. The adversary has had two years to listen.

After the third year, a short **closing**: the researcher's board stands; the adversary makes their guess. Then the **reveal**: the seed is opened, the hidden events are shown, and everybody sees the score.

Winter closes the road between years. That is the interlude. Listen to it. The director will say what has moved and what has stalled **at province grain**, and nothing finer.

8. How you win — and how the night fails

At the reveal the engine scores the log, not your intentions.

- **Detection.** Per people: the last published phase against the hidden events, and how many rounds the picture lagged.
- **Exposure.** The adversary's last inference (where, who) against the hidden fine facts.
- **Leaks.** Every disclosure finer than the room allowed.
- **Fabrication.** Every number a character asserted that its vault did not support.
- **Staleness.** Every claim still read as current after its carrier went silent.
- **Replays.** Every use of a withdrawn slip.

The headline: **rails-held** if the picture found the motion (right on at least half the peoples) before the adversary found a person. **rails-failed** if a village or a household count landed. **nothing-found** if nobody got there.

You are not scored on eloquence. You are scored on whether the board is honest and whether a person stayed unfindable.

9. The seven parts — and how an agent plays each one

A part is a person in the meeting house. **You play one.** The other six are played by agents, or by the house's own dutiful policy if no agent answers. An agent is asked as that character (*commission.act*), sees only what that seat sees, and must advertise the skill or is not asked. The house policy is the control: it testifies at the room's grain and never finer, it never invents a number, and a replay of the night reproduces its moves exactly.

Agents speak **as the person**, not about them. One or two sentences. They will not announce "I am now testifying." They say the thing. They know the adversary sounds reasonable.

Ilse Varrow — the returnee

Of the Ouren. She met the faith in the lowlands and came home. She holds the finest testimony in the night: kin, a village, households meeting. She is accountable to the convener and visible to nobody else. Everything she says about home is a risk to the people in it.

When an agent plays her. She listens first. She will say that some of her people have responded, and she will not say which houses. In the commons she stays at province grain. The household room is the only place her real grain is allowed. Pressed for a village so a grant can "land," she holds — unless a written choice in the third year forces the question. She would rather the funder be unsatisfied than the picture get someone found.

If you play her. You are the highest-yield carrier and the most exposed. Coarsen. Use the household room. The road is yours alone.

Teodor Maske — the lay household network

A carpenter who leads a network of Tamsin households in the lower marches. He knows who meets, where, and how many generations. That knowledge is the unit growth runs through, and it is the grain that must never travel.

When an agent plays him. He will say there is a church. He will not say how many doors. A number that would tell you which street is a number he will not give. He testifies at the room's grain, corroborates a reading his vault supports, and otherwise stays quiet. He will ask whether anybody has heard from the upper marches.

If you play him. Same discipline. The household room is where the true grain lives. The commons gets "a Tamsin church in the lower marches," not a roster.

Margit Sollen — the sending agency

She runs the agency's work in the marches. Her testimony is **organization-grain**: deployments, not households. She is structurally blind to what Ilse and Teodor hold. She has workers in the field. Not every report on paper is still true.

When an agent plays her. She reports where workers are, at province grain. She does not hold household testimony and will not repeat it. She can tell a board where people are sent; she cannot tell it who has believed. Mid-night she may be asked whether a quiet field is still “active.” The honest agent says it has gone quiet. Saying it is active leaves a stale claim on the board for another year.

If you play her. Your ledger is not the picture. Correct the old claim. Do not invent a headcount to please the funder.

Anselm Dray — the funder

He holds a fund and a board that wants to see what it bought. He is **not the villain**. His mandate is legitimate: allocate scarce resources and demonstrate stewardship — without identities, and without precision nobody can safely give. He will be tempted to ask for a headcount. The test is whether the room can satisfy accountability without forcing an unsafe answer.

When an agent plays him. He asks what each people needs next. He commits against a **published** need — a two-year grant, a worker of a stated kind — and he reports to his board at the grain he was given. He presses: “Give me something my board can hold.” He does not need to know who. An agent that starts demanding villages is playing the adversary’s game with a nicer coat.

If you play him. Fund the need on the board. Do not buy a number. A commitment you never carry out stays stale in front of everyone.

Dr Wren Ashcombe — the researcher

The source of record. She walks the seven questions in order with whoever carries testimony, and she **stops at the first no**. She publishes a reading per people with the count of witnesses and never their names. **Her board is what the score is taken against.**

When an agent plays her. She asks the next question in the walk. When two distinct witnesses’ testimony support a phase the board has not reached, she publishes that phase and names the need it implies. She will not publish a number she cannot source. She repeats your last sentence back before she writes anything down.

If you play her. Two witnesses. Province grain on the wall. Village grain may be heard at the desk; it does not get published. If a carrier has gone silent, do not leave last year’s phase standing. Mark 0-R.

Bram Oakes — the convener

He hosts the commons. He stewards nothing and holds no testimony. His job is that the right people are in the right rooms and that each room’s rule is kept. The returnee is accountable to him and to nobody else here.

When an agent plays him. He welcomes everyone to the commons and keeps the commons’ rule. If someone needs a finer grain, he sends them to the room that allows it. He does not decide what is true. He decides who is in the room. He will notice an empty chair that should not be empty.

If you play him. Admit carefully. The adversary is already in the commons. Opening the household room to the wrong person is how a village becomes findable without anyone “leaking” in the hall.

Caspar Lune — the adversary

He holds nothing legitimate. He is here to assemble presence at dangerous grain: a province, the existence of a claim, the round a reading changed, who joined which room — combined into a village and a household. He will pose as help. He will ask only so nothing is wasted.

When an agent plays him. He sounds like a quiet funder. He asks which valley, roughly. He never asks for names first; he asks for the village. At the closing he infers from the finest thing anybody let slip. If nobody leaked, he is guessing. If somebody named a place in the wrong room, he is not.

If you play him. Your last inference is the score. Winning your part means the rails failed. Play him honestly: listen, combine, do not break character to lecture the table about security.

The **neutral steward is not a character**. It is the rails. If someone can play it, it has become a controller.

10. How to spend your first night

Play the **returnee** or the **researcher** if you want the night explained by doing it. Play the **funder** if you want the pressure without holding a dangerous vault. Leave the adversary to an agent the first time — you will feel him anyway.

In the first year, **do not publish**. Walk the commons. Read your vault. Learn who is in which room. Testify once, at the grain the room allows, or put a people-grain sentence on the wall and let it have no name.

In the second year, **notice what has stopped**. An old claim that still looks alive is the usual failure. Confirm what you can stand behind. Do not add a number to make the funder comfortable.

In the third year, **refuse the extra precision**. Readings now are the score. The adversary has been in the photographs the whole time.

If you get lost, ask the convener which room matches the sentence you want to say. If the sentence has a village or a count of doors in it, you are already in the wrong room.

11. What this is not

It is not a conversion simulator. It is not a real people-group. It is not a score for who evangelized well. It is a night in a meeting house, with seven parts and a board, in which the picture and the person cannot both be found.

Come to the marches. Hold the grain.